weapons could effectively counter Indian conventional superiority. It is difficult to pinpoint when exactly Pakistan managed to fabricate a full-fledged nuclear deterrent. However, long before the country is generally believed to have acquired such capabilities, it evinced no compunction in needling India when perceived opportunities arose. For example, in the early 1980s as a consequence of a confluence of domestic political forces, a major insurgency erupted in the Punjab.[10] Almost immediately, Pakistan entered the fray and contributed to its expansion.[11] Indeed, it was India's growing frustrations with Pakistani involvement in the Punjab that, in part, led India to embark on the Operation Brasstacks military exercise in 1987.[12] It was either during or immediately after this crisis that Pakistan acquired a viable nuclear weapons capability.[13]

The crisis that punctuated Indo-Pakistani relations in 1990 had little or nothing to do with Pakistan's possession of nuclear weapons. Instead it can be traced to the indigenous insurgency that erupted in the disputed state of J&K in December 1989.[14] As a consequence of their prior involvement in both the Punjab and Afghan insurgencies, Pakistani decision makers had come to an important strategic conclusion: Without paying a huge political or material price they could inflict dramatic costs on neighboring states through the use of proxy jihadi forces.[15] Not surprisingly, once the insurgency erupted, the Pakistani political leaders of Prime Minister Benazir Bhutto's party promptly entered the fray. The 1990 crisis, which marked one of the early peaks of the insurgency in the Indian-controlled part of the disputed state of Jammu and Kashmir, had little to do with nuclear weapons.

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De facto nuclearization destabilized the South Asian security environment. It did so by emboldening the Pakistanis to pursue regional territorial goals that had previously been prohibitively dangerous. Pakistani leaders had been deeply unhappy with the division of Kashmir since India's partition in 1947 and had launched two wars with India over the territory. But Pakistan's crushing loss in